

DESTINY OF THE DYNASTY

Political turmoil gains momentum in the state as long term allies begin to distance themselves from the DMK which is already beset with intra-party problems caused by rifts in the ruling family

■ By Saravanan

Two weeks ago, when Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi shot off a poem in his party organ *Murasoli*, asking his family to be united and caring, it clearly showed the near desperation of the once-powerful DMK supremo to keep his flock together. Family discord was compounding his problems on other fronts—be it within the coalition, at the Centre, in his own Cabinet or with the Opposition.

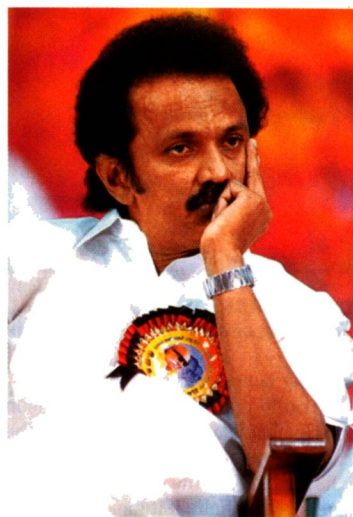
It is evident that Karunanidhi's younger son M.K. Stalin has won the hearts of the people and the bureaucracy in Chennai with his cultivated demeanour. Even the DMK brass accepts him as Karunanidhi's natural heir, who is unable to anoint him officially for fear of incurring the wrath of elder son Azhagiri whose wish to compete with his brother has come out in the open. Also, to counter the increasing importance given to Stalin's half sister Kanimozhi, Karunanidhi's move to induct his daughter Kayalvizhi into the party has also not been taken well.

The cold war between the chief minister's siblings is becoming increasingly visible at public platforms. But Karunanidhi's desperate efforts to bring his warring siblings together are more than evident, when recently while inaugurating a bridge in Chennai, he said, "I would like to remind Stalin and his friends that other bridges also need to be built."

Family squabbles have aggravated at a time when a split in the existing coalition in the coming parliamentary elections is likely to affect the DMK's prospects at the Centre. Political ob-

servers say that with the comrades declaring the Congress their enemy and nursing a Third Front ambition, it is only natural for the Left in the state to sever ties with the DMK. "We can see an anti-communist stance in the recent statements of DMK leaders," said CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan. But in a polite reply in *Murasoli*, Karunanidhi clarified that "the DMK never deliberately attempted to make enemies of friendly parties".

The chief minister's concern is understandable, considering his regime is also witnessing a slew of charges over inefficiency and corruption. His reluctance in taking stern action against erring officials has only provided more fodder to the Opposition. And in the process, the Government's image has



FIRST AMONG EQUALS: M.K. Stalin



LAST HURRAH: Karunanidhi with his daughter Kanimozhi (left)

taken a huge beating.

Karunanidhi has come under flak on a number of occasions. When an audio tape of Social Welfare Minister A. Poongothai asking a vigilance officer not to take action against a relative was leaked, it was much later that he asked the minister to quit. Similarly, he took his time before dismissing handloom minister N.K.K.P. Raja, who was charged with abducting a family and threatening them to sell plum real estate to him. Much to Karunanidhi's embarrassment, several other ministers too are facing similar charges. Among them are Tourism Minister Suresh Rajan, Labour Welfare Minister T.M. Anbarasan, Agriculture Minister Veerapandi S. Arumugam, and Food Minister E.V. Velu.

Apart from a list of corrupt ministers, Karunanidhi also has to contend with issues relating to governance. "The DMK Government is losing its popularity. In every district, ministers are taking law into their own hands," says the BJP's Tamil Nadu chief L. Ganesan.